

- **Take turns.** Alternate merging with vehicles from the other lane, like the teeth of a zipper coming together.
- **Be courteous.** Allow one vehicle from the ending lane to merge in front of you, then merge into the open lane.
- **Maintain speed.** Continue merging at a steady pace, matching the speed of traffic in the open lane.

5.4 | TIME

To reduce risk, give yourself plenty of time to evaluate and move through traffic. You can use a technique, like eye-lead time, which allows you to scan the road ahead for potential hazards. Eye-lead time is an important part of defensive driving. It gives you time to see, analyze, and respond to hazards. Scan as far as you can see ahead and to the sides. Use your mirrors to scan behind. The earlier you identify a hazard, the more time you have to prepare for it and the more time those around you have to adjust to your changes. This is a proactive approach to driving. It's less risky than relying on your reactions to avoid danger.

COUNT SECONDS

Practice judging the space your vehicle will travel in a short amount of time using this simple exercise:

1. Pick out a marker, such as a road sign or utility pole, that you think is 15 seconds ahead of your vehicle.
2. Count until you reach the marker.

Guessing before you count helps you develop the ability to correctly estimate the distance your vehicle will travel in seconds. Your accuracy will improve as you continue to practice this method.

It is crucial to give yourself time to stop or maneuver around obstacles and in unpredictable traffic situations. With enough

